

Aakansha Jain

Department of Economics, Iowa State University
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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, Iowa State University, USA	May 2027 (expected)
M.Sc. in Economics, Shiv Nadar University, India	2020
B.Sc. in Economics, University of Calcutta, India (Minor: Mathematics & Statistics; First-Class Honours)	2017

FIELDS OF INTEREST

Labor Economics, Agricultural Labor, Development Economics, Rural Development, Economics of Education, Migration, Applied Microeconomics

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Manternach, R., **Jain, A.**, Orazem, P.F., & Soborowicz, L. (2025). “[Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?](#)” *Growth and Change*, 56(4): e70064.

Book Chapters

Jain, A., Montenegro, C., & Orazem, P.F. (forthcoming, 2026). “Youth Labor Markets in High- and Low-Income Countries.” In K. Leicht (Ed.), *Oxford University Handbook on the 21st Century Economy*. Oxford University Press.

WORKING PAPERS

“[The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor](#)”

Job Market Paper; solo-authored

H-2A guestworker certifications grew fivefold between 2008 and 2024 while the settled non-citizen farm workforce fell by a third. Using a panel of 740 commuting zones and a shift-share (Bartik) instrumental variables design built on national enforcement shocks, I show that the rise of H-2A is a causal response to the loss of settled workers: farms take on 1.7 to 2.5 certifications for each worker lost, about 1.4 to one in worker-months, and enforcement-driven decline accounts for roughly half of national H-2A growth.

“[College Wage Premiums in India: Trends and Spatial Decomposition, 1987–2012](#)”

solo-authored

Traces the college wage premium across five waves of India’s National Sample Survey, 1987–2012, a period when tertiary enrollment nearly tripled. The premium rose throughout, and zone-level decompositions show that the young–old premium gap closed where college supply expanded most.

“[An Overview of the 2024 Iowa State University Alumni Survey](#)”

with A. Andrade, J. Eyles, K. Kimle, P.F. Orazem, and R. Unal

Documents the design, sample construction, and descriptive findings of the 2024 ISU alumni survey, covering graduating cohorts from 1982 to 2023 with over 5,000 usable responses. The primary data reference for subsequent work drawing on the survey.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

“Does Broadband Close the Rural Education Gap?”

with L. Han and J.V. Winters

Asks whether federally subsidized broadband raises college enrollment among rural high-school graduates. The Connect America Fund Phase II set block eligibility ex ante through an FCC cost model and deployed in stages over 2015–2021, leaving nearly half of eligible blocks unserved as controls. A staggered difference-in-differences design with block and cohort fixed effects links deployment records to restricted ACS microdata.

“Returns to Farming Among ISU Alumni”

with I. Cho and P.F. Orazem

Compares the household income of farmers and observationally similar nonfarm workers among ISU graduates, using matching estimators and an endogenous treatment effects model. Farmers earn significantly less, even though household income includes off-farm earnings. Among all farmers the gap is concentrated in nonrural households; among full-time farmers it holds in rural areas as well.

“Firm Entry and Serial Entrepreneurship Among ISU Alumni”

with D. Lin and P.F. Orazem

Examines how labor market conditions at graduation shape entrepreneurial entry among ISU alumni across the 2008 and 2024 surveys. A higher Iowa unemployment rate at graduation delays business entry, with the gap emerging around year five; national conditions show no such effect.

POLICY REPORTS

- Crespi, G., and **Jain, A.** (2026). “[Where Do They Go? Migration Patterns of Iowa State University Alumni.](#)” *Agricultural Policy Review*, Winter 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- Andrade, A., Eyles, J., **Jain, A.**, Kimle, K., Orazem, P.F., & Unal, R. (2025). “[How a Land Grant College Affects Business and Job Creation.](#)” *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2025. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

Media Mentions

- “[Iowa State college graduates left for bigger cities, but they’re returning to Iowa.](#)” *Axios Des Moines*, April 21, 2026. Coverage of Crespi and Jain (2026).

Outreach Writing

- **Jain, A.** (2024). “[How to Compute Real Income or Real Value of a Given Currency?](#)” *Ask an Economist*, Department of Economics, Iowa State University, November 6, 2024.

CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS

- Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, Houston, TX Nov 2026
Selected Paper: “The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor.”
- Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA), Kansas City, MO Jul 2026
Selected Paper: “The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor.”
- Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL Mar 2025
“Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?”

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Standalone Instructor, Iowa State University

ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions

Spring 2025

- Designed and delivered a full-semester course for 60 students in a subject outside my primary field, building the syllabus, lecture content, and all assessments.
- Administered homework and weekly quizzes through Pearson MyLab and Canvas; coordinated a teaching assistant for review sessions and grading.
- Learned to design courses for undergraduate audiences: aligning assessments with lectures, keeping grades visible, and pacing material to the class.

Teaching Assistant, Iowa State University

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics

Spring 2026, Fall 2023

ECON 2070: Quantitative Methods in Economic Analysis I

Fall 2025

ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions

Fall 2024

ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics (lab and online sections)

Fall 2022 – Winter 2024

- Led recitations, weekly quantitative labs, and pre-exam review sessions across principles and intermediate courses; designed and graded quizzes and exams.
- Ran fully online and accelerated sections, including a one-month asynchronous course with recorded review sessions, live Q&A, and virtual office hours.
- A faculty observer highlighted my success in getting students to answer questions in class, and course evaluations included requests for more of my instruction.

Mentorship

Tutor, “Economics Help Room”

Spring 2023 – Fall 2024

- Tutored undergraduates one-on-one across principles and intermediate courses in weekly walk-in hours.
- Ranked among the top 3 of 25 teaching assistants (Fall 2024) with the top supervisor rating.

Graduate Mentor, “Saturday Morning Breakfast Club”

Spring 2023 – Present

- Mentor undergraduates through their own research projects at weekly group meetings: framing research questions, finding data sources, building datasets, and writing replicable Stata code.
- Breakfast Club collaborations produced papers listed above, including a *Growth and Change* article with an undergraduate first author and an *Agricultural Policy Review* article with an undergraduate coauthor.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, Department of Economics, Iowa State University (multiple appointments)

Spring 2024 – Present

- ISU Alumni Survey project with Prof. Peter F. Orazem: built the 2024 survey data pipeline from raw Qualtrics responses (Summer 2024), constructed rural–urban migration measures across graduating cohorts (Summer 2025), and currently work quarter-time on alumni entrepreneurship and the returns to farming (Fall 2026).
- Beginning agricultural extension work with Dr. Rabail Chandio (Fall 2026).
- Contributed to the empirical analysis of “Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?” (*Growth and Change*, 2025) and supported the undergraduate researchers on the project (Spring 2024).

Research Assistant, Indian School of Business**Summer 2022**

- Contributed to a pilot RCT evaluating Bihar's Public Distribution System; managed survey logistics and data cleaning.

Research Assistant, IFMR LEAD**Aug 2021 – Mar 2022**

- Analyzed differential impacts of COVID-19 on the mental well-being of men and women using difference-in-differences; conducted data analysis in Stata and geo-coding with the Google API. PIs: Amrita Dhillon (KCL), Farzana Afridi (ISI Delhi), Sanchari Roy (KCL).

Research Assistant, King's College London**Jun 2020 – Jul 2021**

- Developed composite measures of state performance for MGNREGA and PMGSY; supervised a team of research assistants for quality control of a large administrative dataset. PIs: Amrita Dhillon (KCL), Farzana Afridi (ISI Delhi), Arka Roy Chaudhury (Shiv Nadar).

HONORS AND AWARDS

USDA AMS-AAEA Local Food Economics Data Visualization Challenge, First Place **2026**

- "Mapping the Missing Market Pathways in U.S. Dairy Regions," with A. Basha and H. Lee. [\[GitHub Repository\]](#)
- \$1,200 first-place team prize, plus \$1,200 in AAEA travel support for teams selected for the challenge.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Referee: *Growth and Change*; *Journal of Development Effectiveness***Conferences****Session Moderator, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting** **Nov 2026****Session Moderator, Agricultural & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting** **Jul 2026****Discussant, Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting** **Mar 2025****University****Elected Chair, LAS College, Graduate & Professional Student Senate, ISU** **2023–2024****Senator, Department of Economics, Graduate & Professional Student Senate, ISU** **2023–2024****PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT**

Mentee, Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics (AMIE) **2025–2026****Preparing Future Faculty Course (GRST 5850), Iowa State University** **Fall 2025****PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS**

American Economic Association; Agricultural & Applied Economics Association; Midwest Economics Association

CORE COMPETENCIES

Technical Skills**Software:** Stata, Python, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Google API (geo-coding)**Data:** IPUMS (CPS, ACS, Decennial Census), USDA NASS Census of Agriculture, DOL H-2A

administrative records, ISU Alumni Survey, NSSO (India), DISE (India education)

Methods: Panel data, difference-in-differences, shift-share (Bartik) instrumental variables, event study, regression discontinuity, RCT design and evaluation

Coursework: Machine Learning: A Signal Processing Perspective (EE 425), Iowa State University, Spring 2024

Transferable Skills

Building survey data pipelines from raw responses; supervising research-assistant teams on data quality; mentoring student research projects to publication; writing policy articles for non-academic audiences; designing and teaching a full course

Languages

English (fluent), Hindi (native)

REFERENCES

Dr. John V. Winters

Co-Major Advisor
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Iowa State University
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Dr. Peter F. Orazem

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Dr. Amani Elobeid

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